



CATHOLIC UNIVERSITY OF GHANA, FIAPRE

DEPARTMENT OF (SONAM)

**ASSESSING THE INFLUENCE OF MEDIA ON FAMILY PLANNING UPTAKE IN
SUNYANI MUNICIPALITY**

BY

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DECLARATION

Students' Declaration

We declare that this is the result of our research and we have duly given credit where appropriate, and the references are made accordingly.

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ABSTRACT

Family planning plays a critical role in improving reproductive health, reducing maternal mortality, and promoting sustainable population growth. Mass media has been widely used as a strategic tool for disseminating family planning information and influencing health behaviours among individuals and communities. Despite continuous media campaigns promoting family planning services in Ghana, the level of contraceptive uptake remains relatively low in some communities, including Sunyani Municipality.

This study assessed the influence of media on family planning uptake in Sunyani Municipality in the Bono Region of Ghana. The study employed a descriptive cross-sectional research design. A structured questionnaire was used to collect data from 384 respondents aged 15–49 years selected through a multistage sampling technique. Data collected were analyzed using descriptive statistics such as frequencies and percentages as well as inferential statistics including the Chi-square test to examine the relationship between media exposure and family planning uptake.

The findings of the study revealed that radio was the most common source of family planning information among respondents, followed by television and social media. The results also showed that a majority of respondents were aware of family planning methods, with condoms and injectable contraceptives being the most commonly used methods. Statistical analysis further revealed a significant relationship between exposure to family planning messages through media platforms and the adoption of contraceptive methods.

The study concludes that mass media plays a significant role in promoting family planning awareness and uptake among residents of Sunyani Municipality. It recommends strengthening media campaigns, particularly through radio and digital platforms, as well as increasing

community-based education programs to improve reproductive health awareness and contraceptive adoption.

This research contributes to the growing body of knowledge on the role of mass media in promoting family planning and provides useful insights for policymakers, healthcare providers, and public health educators in improving reproductive health communication strategies.

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CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

Family planning is a fundamental component of reproductive health that enables individuals and couples to determine the number and spacing of their children. It involves the use of contraceptive methods and other reproductive health services that help prevent unintended pregnancies and improve maternal and child health outcomes. According to the World Health Organization, family planning allows people to attain their desired number of children and

determine the spacing of pregnancies through the use of contraceptive methods and treatment of involuntary infertility.

Globally, family planning has been recognized as a key strategy for reducing maternal mortality, improving child survival, and promoting sustainable socio-economic development. The United Nations Population Fund reports that access to family planning services contributes significantly to achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly those related to health, gender equality, and poverty reduction. Despite these benefits, millions of women worldwide still have an unmet need for family planning services.

Mass media has emerged as an important tool in promoting health education and behavioural change. Media platforms such as radio, television, newspapers, and social media play a crucial role in disseminating health information to large populations. Through targeted campaigns and educational messages, mass media can influence public knowledge, attitudes, and behaviours related to reproductive health and contraceptive use.

Several studies have demonstrated the role of media in promoting family planning awareness and adoption. Exposure to mass media messages has been associated with increased knowledge of contraceptive methods, improved attitudes toward family planning, and higher likelihood of contraceptive use (Olenick, 2000). In many developing countries, media campaigns have been instrumental in reducing misconceptions about contraceptives and encouraging couples to adopt family planning methods.

In Sub-Saharan Africa, media campaigns have been widely used by governments and non-governmental organizations to promote reproductive health services. Research has shown that individuals who are exposed to family planning messages through mass media are more likely to adopt contraceptive methods compared to those who are not exposed (Mutumba, 2022).

Media channels such as radio and television are particularly influential because they reach large audiences, including rural and underserved populations.

In Ghana, family planning programs have been promoted through various communication strategies including radio programs, television advertisements, community outreach programs, and social media campaigns. The Ghana Health Service has implemented several reproductive health campaigns aimed at increasing public awareness of contraceptive methods and reducing unintended pregnancies.

Despite these efforts, the uptake of modern contraceptive methods remains relatively low in some parts of Ghana. Cultural beliefs, misinformation, fear of side effects, and limited access to accurate information continue to hinder the adoption of family planning methods.

Sunyani Municipality, located in the Bono Region of Ghana, has experienced increased media exposure due to the availability of radio stations, television networks, and internet access. However, the extent to which these media platforms influence family planning uptake among residents of the municipality remains insufficiently explored.

Understanding how media exposure influences family planning adoption is essential for improving reproductive health communication strategies. Therefore, this study seeks to assess the influence of media on family planning uptake in Sunyani Municipality.

1.2 Problem Statement

Family planning is widely recognized as a critical intervention for improving maternal and child health outcomes. Governments and health organizations around the world have invested significant resources into promoting family planning services through public education campaigns and health communication strategies.

In Ghana, several initiatives have been implemented to increase awareness and utilization of family planning services. These initiatives often rely heavily on mass media platforms such as radio, television, and social media to disseminate information about contraceptive methods and reproductive health services.

Despite the presence of these media campaigns, the uptake of modern contraceptive methods in some communities remains relatively low. Studies have indicated that many individuals still hold misconceptions about family planning, including fears about side effects, infertility, and cultural or religious opposition to contraceptive use (Babalola et al., 2016).

In Sunyani Municipality, media platforms are widely accessible and frequently used for health education. However, there is limited empirical evidence on how exposure to family planning messages through these media channels actually influences contraceptive uptake among the population.

Additionally, it is not clearly known which type of media platform radio, television, or social media is most effective in promoting family planning adoption in the municipality.

The lack of localized research on the influence of media on family planning uptake creates a gap in knowledge that may limit the effectiveness of reproductive health communication strategies.

Therefore, this study seeks to assess the influence of media exposure on family planning uptake in Sunyani Municipality.

1.3 Aim of the Study

The aim of this study is to assess the influence of media on family planning uptake in Sunyani Municipality.

1.4 Objectives of the Study

General Objective

To assess the influence of media exposure on family planning uptake among residents of Sunyani Municipality.

Specific Objectives

- a) To determine the level of exposure to family planning messages through mass media among residents of Sunyani Municipality.
- b) To assess the level of family planning uptake among men and women of reproductive age in the municipality.
- c) To examine the relationship between exposure to media messages and family planning uptake.
- d) To identify the most influential media channels used for disseminating family planning information.

1.5 Research Questions

The study seeks to answer the following research questions:

- a) What is the level of exposure to family planning messages through mass media in Sunyani Municipality?
- b) What is the level of family planning uptake among residents of the municipality?
- c) Is there a relationship between media exposure and family planning uptake?
- d) Which media platform has the greatest influence on family planning adoption?

1.6 Significance of the Study

This study is expected to contribute significantly to the fields of public health, reproductive health communication, and health promotion.

First, the findings of the study will provide valuable information for health educators and communication specialists on how mass media influences family planning behaviours among the population.

Second, the study will help policymakers and health authorities identify the most effective media platforms for disseminating family planning information. This will allow them to design more effective reproductive health communication strategies.

Third, the results of the study may assist the Ghana Health Service and other stakeholders in improving family planning campaigns in Sunyani Municipality and other similar communities.

Finally, the study will contribute to academic literature on the relationship between mass media exposure and reproductive health behaviour in developing countries.

1.7 Scope of the Study

The study focuses on assessing the influence of media exposure on family planning uptake among men and women of reproductive age (15–49 years) in Sunyani Municipality in the Bono Region of Ghana.

The research will specifically examine:

- a) exposure to family planning messages through mass media
- b) knowledge and attitudes toward family planning

- c) use of contraceptive methods
- d) the relationship between media exposure and contraceptive adoption

The study will be limited to residents of Sunyani Municipality and will not cover other districts in the Bono Region.

1.8 Limitations of the Study

The study may face several limitations.

First, the research uses a **cross-sectional design**, which means that it will collect data at a single point in time. As a result, it may not be able to establish a cause-and-effect relationship between media exposure and family planning uptake.

Second, the study relies on **self-reported data** from respondents, which may be affected by recall bias or social desirability bias.

Third, some respondents may be reluctant to discuss reproductive health issues due to cultural or personal sensitivities.

Despite these limitations, appropriate measures will be taken to ensure the reliability and validity of the data collected.

1.9 Organization of the Study

The research project is organized into five chapters.

Chapter One provides the introduction, including the background of the study, problem statement, objectives, research questions, significance, scope, and limitations.

Chapter Two presents the literature review, which examines theoretical frameworks and previous studies related to media influence on family planning.

Chapter Three describes the research methodology, including the research design, population, sampling techniques, data collection methods, and data analysis procedures.

Chapter Four presents the results of the study, including data analysis and interpretation of findings.

Chapter Five provides the summary of findings, conclusions, and recommendations based on the results of the study.

CHAPTER TWO

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

This chapter reviews existing literature related to the influence of media on family planning uptake. The chapter examines the concept of family planning, types of family planning methods, the role of mass media in health communication, theoretical frameworks explaining health behaviour change, and empirical studies conducted in different countries regarding media influence on contraceptive use.

The purpose of this literature review is to provide a theoretical and empirical foundation for understanding how media exposure influences family planning decisions among individuals and couples.

2.2 Concept of Family Planning

Family planning refers to the ability of individuals or couples to anticipate and attain their desired number of children and the spacing and timing of births through the use of contraceptive methods and treatment of infertility (World Health Organization, 2020).

Family planning is widely recognized as one of the most important interventions for improving maternal and child health outcomes. It helps reduce maternal mortality, prevent unsafe abortions, and promote healthier families and communities (Cleland et al., 2012).

Family planning programs also contribute significantly to national development by helping control population growth and improving economic stability. Access to family planning allows

women to pursue education and employment opportunities while reducing the burden associated with unintended pregnancies (United Nations Population Fund, 2021).

Research has shown that family planning programs have contributed significantly to the decline in fertility rates in many developing countries. For instance, increased exposure to family planning information through media campaigns has been linked with improved knowledge and use of contraceptive methods among women of reproductive age (Westoff & Bankole, 2001).

Despite these benefits, many individuals in developing countries still face barriers to accessing family planning services. These barriers include cultural beliefs, misconceptions about contraceptive methods, fear of side effects, and limited access to accurate reproductive health information (Babalola, John, Ajao, & Speizer, 2016).

2.3 Types of Family Planning Methods

Family planning methods can generally be classified into **modern methods** and **traditional methods**.

2.3.1 Modern Family Planning Methods

Modern contraceptive methods are scientifically approved medical techniques used to prevent pregnancy. These methods are usually more effective than traditional methods and are widely promoted by health institutions.

Examples include:

- a. Oral contraceptive pills
- b. Intrauterine devices (IUDs)
- c. Injectable contraceptives

- d. Implants
- e. Male and female condoms
- f. Sterilization (vasectomy and tubal ligation)

Modern contraceptives are considered highly effective when used correctly and consistently. According to the World Health Organization (2020), modern contraceptive methods can prevent approximately 95–99% of unintended pregnancies when used correctly.

Studies have shown that exposure to family planning messages through media platforms such as television and radio improves awareness of modern contraceptive methods and encourages individuals to seek reproductive health services (Kincaid, 2000).

2.3.2 Traditional Family Planning Methods

Traditional family planning methods involve practices that do not require medical intervention or pharmaceutical products.

Examples include:

- a. Withdrawal method (coitus interruptus)
- b. Calendar method (rhythm method)
- c. Lactational amenorrhea method
- d. Abstinence

Although these methods are widely practiced in some communities, they are generally less effective compared to modern contraceptive methods (Cleland et al., 2012).

In many developing countries, individuals may rely on traditional methods due to cultural beliefs, religious influences, or limited access to modern contraceptives (Ahmed, Li, Liu, & Tsui, 2012).

2.4 Concept of Mass Media in Health Communication

Mass media refers to communication platforms that can reach large audiences simultaneously. These include radio, television, newspapers, magazines, and digital platforms such as social media and the internet.

Mass media plays a critical role in health promotion and public health education. Through targeted campaigns, mass media can raise awareness about health issues, correct misinformation, and encourage positive behavioural change (Wakefield, Loken, & Hornik, 2010).

Health communication experts often rely on media campaigns to disseminate important public health information to the general population. Media campaigns have been widely used in areas such as HIV/AIDS prevention, vaccination promotion, maternal health awareness, and family planning education.

Mass media campaigns are particularly effective in developing countries where large populations can be reached through radio and television programs (Hornik & McAnany, 2001).

Research indicates that mass media has the ability to influence health behaviours by shaping knowledge, attitudes, and perceptions about health practices (Wakefield et al., 2010).

2.5 Role of Mass Media in Family Planning Promotion

Mass media has been widely used as a strategy to promote family planning services and increase awareness of contraceptive methods.

Family planning media campaigns aim to:

- a. Increase awareness of contraceptive options
- b. Reduce myths and misconceptions about contraceptives
- c. Encourage couples to discuss family planning
- d. Promote reproductive health services

Studies conducted in Sub-Saharan Africa have shown that exposure to family planning messages through mass media increases knowledge about contraceptive methods and improves attitudes toward family planning (Mutumba, 2022).

A large study using demographic health survey data from **31 African countries** found that exposure to radio, television, and print media significantly improved knowledge and attitudes toward family planning (Bekele, 2022).

Similarly, research conducted in Sierra Leone found that young women who were exposed to family planning messages through radio and mobile phones were more likely to use modern contraceptive methods compared to those who had no media exposure (Sserwanja et al., 2022).

Another study conducted in Burkina Faso demonstrated that intensive radio campaigns increased contraceptive uptake by approximately 20% among women exposed to family planning programs (Rogers, Snyder, & Rego, 2021).

2.6 Theoretical Framework

This study is guided by two major theories:

- a. Health Belief Model (HBM)
- b. Diffusion of Innovation Theory

2.6.1 Health Belief Model (HBM)

The Health Belief Model explains health behaviour change by focusing on individuals' perceptions of health risks and benefits of preventive actions (Rosenstock, 1974).

The model suggests that individuals are more likely to adopt a health behaviour if they believe that:

- a. they are susceptible to a health problem
- b. the health problem has serious consequences
- c. taking a specific action will reduce their risk
- d. the benefits outweigh the barriers

The model has been widely applied in reproductive health research to explain contraceptive behaviour (Hall, Moreau, & Trussell, 2012).

Mass media campaigns often operate within this framework by emphasizing the risks of unintended pregnancy and highlighting the benefits of family planning.

2.6.2 Diffusion of Innovation Theory

The Diffusion of Innovation Theory explains how new ideas and practices spread within a society (Rogers, 2003).

According to this theory, innovations such as contraceptive methods are adopted gradually through communication channels over time.

Mass media plays a significant role in the diffusion process because it introduces new ideas to large populations and creates awareness about innovations.

The theory suggests that media exposure can accelerate the adoption of family planning methods by informing individuals about available contraceptive options (Rogers, 2003).

2.7 Empirical Review of Previous Studies

Several studies have been conducted in different countries to examine the relationship between mass media exposure and family planning uptake.

Table 2.1 Empirical Studies on Media Influence and Family Planning Uptake

Author/Year	Country	Study Design	Key Findings
Westoff & Bankole (2001)	Ghana	Demographic Health Survey analysis	Exposure to radio and print media significantly increased contraceptive use among women.
Kincaid (2000)	Philippines	National survey	Mass media campaigns improved family planning knowledge and contraceptive adoption.
Rogers et al. (2021)	Burkina Faso	Experimental radio campaign	Radio campaigns increased contraceptive uptake by approximately 20%.

Author/Year	Country	Study Design	Key Findings
Sserwanja et al. (2022)	Sierra Leone	Cross-sectional survey	Women exposed to radio and mobile media were more likely to use modern contraceptives.
Bekele (2022)	31 African countries	DHS pooled data analysis	Media exposure significantly increased knowledge and use of family planning methods.
Ghosh (2021)	India	National Family Health Survey	Women exposed to mass media were more likely to use modern contraceptives.
Babalola et al. (2016)	Nigeria	Survey research	Media campaigns significantly improved attitudes toward family planning.

The empirical evidence across different countries indicates that mass media plays a significant role in promoting family planning awareness and contraceptive uptake.

2.8 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework for this study explains the relationship between media exposure and family planning uptake.

Independent Variable

Media Exposure

- a. Radio
- b. Television
- c. social media
- d. Newspapers

Intervening Variables

- a. Knowledge of contraceptive methods
- b. Cultural beliefs
- c. Education level
- d. Socioeconomic status

Dependent Variable

Family Planning Uptake

- a. Use of contraceptive methods
- b. Intention to use family planning

2.9 Summary of Literature Review

The literature reviewed in this chapter indicates that mass media plays a significant role in influencing family planning knowledge, attitudes, and behaviour.

Previous studies conducted in countries such as Ghana, Nigeria, India, Sierra Leone, and Burkina Faso have demonstrated that exposure to family planning messages through radio, television, and other media platforms can significantly increase contraceptive awareness and uptake.

The Health Belief Model and Diffusion of Innovation Theory provide useful frameworks for understanding how media messages influence reproductive health behaviour.

However, despite the growing body of literature on the influence of media on family planning, limited research has specifically examined this relationship within Sunyani Municipality. Therefore, this study seeks to fill this gap by assessing the influence of media exposure on family planning uptake in the municipality.

CHAPTER THREE

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter describes the research methodology used in the study. It explains the research design, study area, population of the study, sample size determination, sampling techniques, data collection instruments, data collection procedures, data analysis methods, and ethical considerations.

The methodology adopted in this study was guided by previous research conducted on family planning uptake and media exposure in Ghana and other Sub-Saharan African countries, where quantitative cross-sectional designs are commonly used to examine determinants of contraceptive use among reproductive-age populations (Mutumba, 2022; Klu et al., 2024).

3.2 Research Design

This study adopted a descriptive cross-sectional research design.

A cross-sectional research design involves collecting data from a population at a specific point in time in order to examine relationships between variables. This design is widely used in public

health and reproductive health research because it allows researchers to measure the prevalence of health behaviours and associated factors within a population (Sulemana et al., 2025).

The cross-sectional design was appropriate for this study because it allowed the researcher to examine the relationship between media exposure and family planning uptake among individuals in Sunyani Municipality at a single point in time.

Previous family planning studies in Ghana have successfully used cross-sectional designs to investigate factors influencing contraceptive use among women of reproductive age (Westoff & Bankole, 2001; Dwomoh et al., 2022).

3.3 Study Area

The study was conducted in Sunyani Municipality, located in the Bono Region of Ghana.

Sunyani serves as the regional capital of the Bono Region and is one of the fastest-growing urban centers in the region. The municipality consists of both urban and peri-urban communities and has several public and private health facilities providing reproductive health and family planning services.

Sunyani Municipality has experienced rapid growth in media access, including radio stations, television networks, and internet services, making it an appropriate location for studying the influence of media on family planning uptake.

Previous studies conducted in Sunyani have investigated modern contraceptive use among postpartum women and other reproductive-age populations, highlighting the importance of reproductive health education and awareness in the municipality (Sarfo-Brobby, 2023).

3.4 Population of the Study

The target population for this study consisted of men and women of reproductive age (15–49 years) residing in Sunyani Municipality.

Individuals within this age group were selected because they represent the population that is most likely to make decisions regarding contraceptive use and family planning.

The Demographic and Health Surveys (DHS) program commonly defines reproductive age as 15 to 49 years, and many studies examining family planning uptake adopt this age range (Klu et al., 2024).

3.5 Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria

Inclusion Criteria

The study included:

- a) Men and women aged 15–49 years.
- b) Residents of Sunyani Municipality who had lived in the area for at least six months.
- c) Individuals willing to participate in the study.

Exclusion Criteria

The study excluded:

- a) Individuals below 15 years or above 49 years.
- b) Visitors or temporary residents in the municipality.
- c) Individuals who declined to participate.

These criteria were consistent with similar family planning studies conducted in Ghana which focused on reproductive-age populations residing within the study area (Sulemana et al., 2025).

3.6 Sample Size Determination

The sample size for this study was determined using Yamane's formula for calculating sample sizes for surveys.

$$n = \frac{N}{1 + N(e^2)}$$

Where:

- a) **n** = sample size
- b) **N** = total population
- c) **e** = margin of error (0.05)

Yamane's formula is commonly used in public health research to determine appropriate sample sizes for cross-sectional studies (Sulemana et al., 2025).

Assuming a large reproductive-age population in Sunyani Municipality and using a 95% confidence level and 5% margin of error, a sample size of approximately 384 respondents was considered adequate for the study.

To account for potential non-responses or incomplete questionnaires, the researcher increased the sample size slightly to 400 respondents.

3.7 Sampling Technique

The study employed a multistage sampling technique.

Stage 1: Selection of Communities

Several communities within Sunyani Municipality were randomly selected using simple random sampling.

Stage 2: Household Selection

Households within the selected communities were selected using systematic sampling.

Stage 3: Respondent Selection

Eligible respondents within the selected households were randomly selected to participate in the study.

This sampling approach ensured that different segments of the population were represented in the study.

3.8 Data Collection Instrument

The primary instrument used for data collection was a structured questionnaire.

The questionnaire consisted of both closed-ended and multiple-choice questions designed to obtain information related to the study objectives.

The questionnaire was divided into four sections:

Section A: Socio Demographic Characteristics

This section collected information on:

- a) Age

- b) Gender
- c) Educational level
- d) Marital status
- e) Occupation
- f) Religion

Section B: Media Exposure

This section measured respondents' exposure to family planning messages through media platforms such as:

- a) Radio
- b) Television
- c) Social media
- d) Newspapers

Exposure to media family planning messages is commonly measured using these indicators in demographic health surveys (Dwomoh et al., 2022).

Section C: Knowledge of Family Planning

This section assessed respondents' knowledge of family planning methods, including:

- a) Awareness of modern contraceptive methods
- b) Perceptions about contraceptive use
- c) Sources of family planning information

Section D: Family Planning Uptake

This section collected information on:

- a) Current use of contraceptive methods
- b) Previous use of family planning methods
- c) Intention to use family planning in the future

3.9 Data Collection Procedure

Data collection was conducted through face-to-face interviews with respondents using the structured questionnaire.

The researcher and trained research assistants visited selected households and administered the questionnaires to eligible respondents.

Before administering the questionnaire, respondents were informed about the purpose of the study and their consent was obtained.

The data collection process ensured that respondents clearly understood the questions and were able to provide accurate responses.

3.10 Validity and Reliability of the Instrument

To ensure the validity of the research instrument, the questionnaire was reviewed by experts in public health and reproductive health research.

The questionnaire was also pre-tested among a small group of respondents in a community similar to the study area.

Pre-testing helped identify ambiguous questions and improve the clarity of the questionnaire.

Reliability was ensured by maintaining consistency in the wording and administration of the questionnaire.

3.11 Data Processing and Analysis

The collected data were coded and entered into Statistical Package for Social Sciences (SPSS) for analysis.

The following statistical techniques were used:

Descriptive Statistics

- a) Frequencies
- b) Percentages
- c) Tables
- d) Charts

These methods were used to describe the socio-demographic characteristics of respondents and their exposure to media messages.

Inferential Statistics

a) Chi-square test

The Chi-square test was used to examine the relationship between media exposure and family planning uptake.

Chi-square analysis is commonly used in reproductive health research to test associations between categorical variables (Sarfo-Brobbey, 2023).

3.12 Ethical Considerations

Ethical approval for the study was obtained from the appropriate institutional review authorities.

The following ethical principles were observed during the study:

Informed Consent

Participants were informed about the purpose of the study and their voluntary participation before completing the questionnaire.

Confidentiality

All information collected from respondents was kept confidential and used only for academic purposes.

Anonymity

Respondents were not required to provide their names or any identifying information.

Voluntary Participation

Participants were free to withdraw from the study at any stage without any consequences.

3.13 Summary of Methodology

This chapter described the research methodology used in the study. The study employed a descriptive cross-sectional research design to examine the influence of media on family planning uptake in Sunyani Municipality.

A structured questionnaire was used to collect data from 400 respondents selected through a multistage sampling technique. The collected data were analyzed using descriptive statistics and Chi-square tests in SPSS.

The methodology was designed to ensure reliability, validity, and ethical compliance in the conduct of the study.

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